sis. By the time the diagnostic cycle is complete, many patients have already progressed to Stage III or IV," he says. "Every delay steals away options: curative surgery, limited-field radiation, organ-preserving therapies."

For 61-year-old Manoj Rao, a farmer from coastal Andhra Pradesh, those delays marked the difference between treatable cancer and a metastasised disease. His persistent cough was treated as infection for months, and later as possible tuberculosis. When scans were finally done, the cancer had already spread to his bones. "Walking was like dragging lead," he says.

A similar trajectory unfolded for 49-year-old Vijay Kumar, an Uber driver from Lucknow, who developed oral cancer. His first symptom was a small ulcer on the tongue that did not heal. It was treated as an infection. Only when the pain began to shoot into his jaw did he reach a specialist, by which time the tumour had advanced and spread locally. "I could not eat or speak properly. It felt like the cancer was swallowing my life piece by piece," he says.

Dr Naveen Hedne, senior consultant for Head-and-Neck Surgical Oncology at the Apollo Proton Cancer Centre in Chennai, explains that this is tragically common. "India is the oral cancer capital of the world," he says. "About 80 per cent of oral cancers in India still present at a very advanced stage." And there is no reason why this should be so. Screening can be directed at high-risk tobacco users rather than the general population. The oral cavity is accessible; even trained primary healthcare workers can identify suspicious lesions early.

Burden of metastatic cancer

For patients, diagnosis is just the start of the ordeal—finances only intensify it. Cancer in India is a chronic, high-frequency illness, demanding repeated interventions. Insurance data reveals just how overwhelming this can be. A 2025 analysis of more than 100,000 cancer insurance claims by health insurance firm Plum found that a typical cancer patient files nearly four claims a year, with one in five filing more than five. For late-stage disease, the burden is far heavier—between 11 and 22 claims over several months, corresponding to chemotherapy cycles, hospital admissions, radiation sessions, scans and emergency complications.

Not just that, each chemotherapy cycle brings pre-authorisation forms, discharge summaries, itemised pharmacy bills and frequent rejections requiring resubmission. While regulations mandate insurer responses to cashless requests within an hour, caregivers describe waiting in billing queues while patients lie sedated beside them, therapy stalled by paperwork.

Costs escalate rapidly. Plum's analysis shows a head-and-neck cancer patient incurring Rs 42 lakh in just over two months, while another advanced cancer patient crossed Rs 40 lakh within three and a half months.

Saurabh Arora, co-founder and CTO of Plum, says this is when families realise they are underinsured. "At least one in five patients exhausts a Rs 5 lakh cover within a year, and cancer treatment can go up to Rs 20-30 lakh," he says. Shrinking payout ratios compound the problem. Many insurers place modern treatments like immunotherapy or oral chemotherapy under high co-pay structures, forcing families to bear half the cost. Insurers also often refuse reimbursement for newer cancer drugs until Indian regulatory approval, even when they are internationally accepted as standard care. "Until faster drug approval pathways exist, families facing serious illness will have to be prepared for significant uncovered expenses," Arora says. He recommends that the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India should mandate minimum payout benchmarks



> **"Once their disease is no longer curable, cancer patients largely disappear from registries and programme metrics. What we do not measure, we do not invest in"**
>
> **DR ISHITA GANDHI**
> *Medical Director, CanSupport*



Illustration by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

TRUE COST OF LATE-STAGE CANCER CARE

- **Advanced cancer treatment can cost ₹20-40 lakh+**
- **1 in 5 insured patients exhaust ₹5 lakh cover in a year**